

Additional Assessments

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Case creation: We expected the admin to create a case when assigning a student to a professor. What actually happens is the student creates the case themselves when they submit their application, and then the admin assigns a professor to that existing case. This isn't necessarily wrong, but it's a different flow than what was described. --- Wang: Not critical, we can consider later.

Final approval — We expected the professor's "Approved" decision to be the final word. What actually happens is the professor's approval puts the case into a "pending admin approval" state, and then the admin has to confirm it. This is actually a good two-step process. Wang: The design is as we planned. No need to change.

Reopening rejected cases — We expected the admin to be able to reopen a rejected case (for example, to get a second opinion from a different professor). The system currently blocks this. Once a case is rejected, nobody, not the admin, not the professor can change it. This may or may not be what we want. —Wang makes sense.

Professor reopening their own rejection — Blocked, as expected. A professor cannot undo their own rejection. They would need to go through the admin, but even the admin can't do it right now. —Wang: see the comment above. Professor shall resort to the admin to reopen a case.

Issues found:

1. **Students can upload files even after rejection - This is one of the biggest problem.** When a case is rejected, the system considers the case "closed," which means there's no active case blocking uploads anymore. Because of that loophole, the upload check says "there's no active case preventing uploads" and lets the student upload new files even though their case was rejected. It matters because, a rejected candidate shouldn't be able to keep uploading documents. It's confusing and could create orphaned files in the system with no case attached to them. The system needs to check for rejected (and approved) cases too, not just active ones. A closed case should still block uploads.—Wang: Hitha please double check the students ability to upload is disabled when an approval/rejection decision is reached and when the student has pressed 'Submit' button.

2. Uploads stay open before professor reviews - When a student first submits their application but before a professor has been assigned, the student can still upload more files. The "Submit" button is supposed to lock uploads, but it doesn't fully lock them in this in-between state. This issue matters because, the whole point of "Submit" is to say "my package is complete, please review it." If the student can keep adding files after submitting, the professor might start reviewing an incomplete or changing set of documents. It can be fixed by when once a student presses Submit, uploads should be locked immediately regardless of whether a professor has been assigned yet. Wang: please take care of this.
3. Experts can set 'additional info' twice in a row - If a professor clicks "Request Additional Information" and then clicks it again before the student does anything, the system accepts it both times instead of recognizing it as a duplicate action. This could generate duplicate notifications to the student and clutter the case history. Wang: Hitha please take a look and take care of it.

What the system does well:

The two-step approval process (professor recommends, admin confirms) is solid

The messaging system between student and professor works

Case numbers are unique

File upload has a 10MB size limit already in place

There's a partial audit log tracking status changes

Email notification hooks exist for status changes

Basic file type restrictions are in place (PDF, DOC, DOCX, TXT)

There's a due date field on cases for tracking deadlines

Improvements/Suggestions:

1. Lock down rejected/approved cases completely — no uploads, no status changes, no modifications by anyone except a specific admin override process if you decide to allow reopening. – Wang: This is as we initially designed.
2. Add an "Under Review" status, right now there's no way for the student to know if the professor has actually started looking at their materials vs. just having them sit in a queue. Wang: Hitha: Please add this status along with Accept/Reject...
3. Consider adding a "Withdrawn" status, if a student decides they don't want to proceed, there's no clean way to close the case without rejecting them. Wang: Yes.
4. For students, show a clear document checklist, the system has a fixed list (SOP, letters of recommendation, resume) required for submission, but the candidate should see exactly what's needed and what they've uploaded so far,

like "3 of 4 required documents uploaded" —Wang: a msg/indicator line on the top to show the number of required documents uploaded would help...

5. For students, Add a progress indicator — candidates should see their case status in plain language: "Waiting for assigning to Professor," "Your materials are under review," "Action needed: professor requested additional documents," "Decision: Approved/Rejected", and "Withdrawn". Wang: These shall be the complete list of status.

6. For students, Add an estimated review timeline, like a simple "Expected review within 10 business days" helps candidates feel less anxious. Wang: Great point. Add a msg line like ' The case is expected to complete the review within 15 business days from submission'.

Second Section of comments

I got some suggestions from a third person about the document system:

Improvements/Suggestions:

1. For experts, add private case notes, experts should be able to write internal evaluation notes that the student cannot see, separate from messages. —Wang: make sense. Notes between professor and admin shall be put in.

2. For experts, add a workload dashboard like to show how many active cases each expert has so admin can distribute candidates evenly. —This is similar to what I had suggested earlier, please consolidate with my earlier comment(regarding adding an expert button and the according dashboard about experts for the admin). Wang: This was what I suggested earlier.

3. For experts, in-browser document preview like now there is partial support, but experts should be able to read a PDF right in the browser without downloading every file. Wang: doesn't it have this function now? double check please

4. For admin, Bulk assignment like if 20 new candidates come in, admin should be able to assign multiple students to experts at once instead of one by one. (Dr. Wang's notes: for now, it's fine. After other changes are made, we may revisit this comment) Wang: we may consider later.

5. For admin, Search and filter cases should be added to filter by status (all pending, all rejected, all approved), by experts, by date range. Wang: yes.

Other relevant improvements:

1. Stricter file validation for checking not just the file extension but the actual file content to make sure a .pdf is really a PDF and not something disguised. —

Wang: leave to later consideration.

2. Rate limiting on messages to prevent spam by limiting how many messages a student or expert can send in a short period. (wang's note: consider later)

3. Better session security the current session tokens are simple and predictable, which is fine for an internal tool but should be hardened if this ever goes external.

wang's note: consider later)

4. File versioning to track which files were part of the original submission vs. which were added after a "more info" request, so the expert can see what's new.

(Wang's note: I felt the current system only keeps one version, and new updates replace the old version automatically. If this is the case, comment 4 may leave to future considerations)

Wang: Overall, the comments make sense. One or two of them are not urgent and may be considered in the future as noted by Wang. Let me know if you think differently.